

Profile

Arline Geronimus: studying the health effects of social injustice



Arline Geronimus was born in Boston, MA, USA, to clinician parents, the children of refugees who came to the USA in the early 20th century, escaping pogroms in what is now Ukraine. "My grandmother actually witnessed perpetrators carve the fetus out of her sister's pregnant body, stuff her empty womb with straw, and set her on fire. And then my grandmother would say, 'there were worse things I saw happen, but they are unspeakable.'" Learning of this family history of persecution, migration, and the subsequent xenophobia, poverty, and antisemitism they faced in the USA, Geronimus recalls, "traumatised me but also sensitised me to the fact that people live through very different experiences depending on characteristics like their religion, race, or socio-economic position; when they were born in history, or what country they were born in". Growing up during the Civil Rights Movement, Geronimus was "very aware of racial injustice, the need to change it and to be an activist about it". Her outlook was also influenced by her lived experience: "because of racial categorisation in the US, my grandparents and parents were considered non-white. I was the first generation of eastern European Jewish descent to be classified as white from birth. So my racial assignment was 'arbitrary', but it served certain very key purposes for the country and for the people who benefited the most in the country. It changed my opportunities compared to my parents, and certainly my grandparents. Being seen as white was of consequence, but there was nothing essential about it."

Because of those experiences, Geronimus' original plan was to become a civil rights attorney, but her education took an interdisciplinary route. She followed an undergraduate degree in political theory at Princeton University with a doctorate in behavioural sciences from the Harvard School of Public Health, and then postdoctoral training at Harvard Medical School. Now a Professor of Health Behaviour and Health Education at the University of Michigan School of Public Health, and Research Professor at the university's Institute for Social Research, USA, her research interests include population health inequity, the structure and impacts of contingencies of social identity, racism and racialisation processes, maternal health, accelerated ageing, and early chronic disease onset. She is perhaps best known for an analytic framework known as weathering that she originated.

Geronimus' first insights into the idea came when she was still a student, working two jobs as a research assistant to a demography professor and at a school for pregnant teenagers. She recalls how "the two experiences illuminated huge disconnects, between what I was reading in the literature as a research assistant—the very negative stereotyping of Black urban teenagers, that they were ignorant of anything about contraception or even their

bodies and reproductive organs—and what I was seeing among actual pregnant teenagers". Geronimus also noticed something else as she got to know the young women. "Some of us became friends, so I was in their homes socially. They were in overcrowded living situations...with both unsafe and unhealthy features in the housing they were able to afford to live in. I'd also go with them to their medical appointments. And I couldn't help but notice how much more sickness they were dealing with than my friends at Princeton or me." She also saw how a considerable number of the young women's relatives were affected by chronic ill health and premature mortality: "Being exposed to all kinds of unhealthy circumstances, whether it's having to work three jobs, toxic working environments, and taking diesel buses to get there...Environmental exposures...Poverty. Food deserts. It's not just that their health is affected by poor nutrition or environmental pollution, or lack of sleep. It's because they're actually doing that high-effort coping against the odds. That's also what drew me to weathering. It's the idea that people can weather a storm, but while there are benefits to withstanding it, the exertion and heroic measures it takes to do so, also erodes your health. It keeps people constantly vigilant, chronically activating physiological stress arousal in their bodies that wears down and dysregulates their body systems, tissues, and organs all the way down to their cells."

Geronimus introduced these ideas in 1990, but recalls, "they were disparaged to the point where I got death threats. Once, as a young junior faculty member at a professional meeting, a more senior faculty member from another university stopped me in the lobby and started yelling at me that I needed to stop saying these things." She persisted because "there was merit to the research...I developed more and more evidence and I was teaching a new generation of people coming in, young minds who were open to it." In 2023, her ideas reached an even wider audience with the publication of her book *Weathering: The Extraordinary Stress of Ordinary Life in an Unjust Society*, a discussion of her decades-long research on the ways systemic injustice erodes the health of marginalised people.

Using this analytical framework, Geronimus' current research is "very concerned with maternal mortality rates that have gone up in the USA over the exact same time period that the US stated goal was to eliminate them", yet, "racial disparities have remained entrenched". She is also working on "the stark racial inequity in who contracted COVID-19 and, of those who did, who was more likely to die from it and at younger ages". For Geronimus "weathering is a very plausible explanation for all of these inequities".

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